

Social Engineering Attacks

Social engineering manipulates people instead of hacking systems directly. Attackers use deception, trust, and psychological tricks to steal information, gain access, or bypass security.

These attacks exploit human nature—curiosity, fear, urgency, or helpfulness—rather than technical weaknesses.

Common techniques

Watch for these methods:

- Phishing: Fake messages tricking you into sharing information
- Pretexting: Made-up stories to get data or access
- Baiting: Tempting offers like free downloads that hide malware
- Tailgating: Following someone into secure areas
- Impersonation: Pretending to be IT support, managers, or colleagues

How attacks work

Attackers research their target first (job role, company details, personal info). They create believable scenarios, build trust or pressure, then push for quick action without verification.

The impact

Individuals lose personal data, suffer financial fraud, or get accounts hacked—often without realising until too late.

Businesses face data breaches, financial loss, and operations halted when employees grant access to sensitive systems.

Warning signs

Spot these red flags:

- Unusual requests for sensitive information
- Pressure or urgency to act immediately
- Anyone avoiding normal verification steps
- Inconsistent details or unfamiliar contacts
- Offers that sound too good to be true

How to protect yourself

Stay safe with these habits:

- Always verify identities before sharing info or granting access

- Follow procedures, even under pressure
- Never disclose sensitive data without authorisation
- Question anything unusual—it's okay to say no

For businesses

Add training, clear policies, access controls, and reporting procedures. Make it normal to challenge suspicious requests.

Social engineering targets people, not just technology. Awareness and verification habits stop these attacks before they succeed.